

Grace



A man in a worn coat sits wide-eyed at a table he did not set: bread, meat, fruit, wine. He brought his hunger. God brought the meal.

Before you gather

- Read Day 4, Grace, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read 2 Samuel 9:6–8, 13 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What is something good in your life you know you could not have bought for yourself?

Leader. Stay off the devotion's "best gift you ever received" question. This one is about inability, which is where grace lives. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Look at his face. He knows this table is not his. Grace is not God topping up what we already cooked. It is God feeding people who came in empty.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Grace is God's unmerited favor freely given to sinners who deserve judgment, granting them salvation, forgiveness, and every spiritual blessing through Jesus Christ. It is not earned, deserved, or repaid; it flows from God's sovereign goodness and love.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek charis — grace, favor, a gift freely given.

MEMORY VERSE · EPHESIANS 2:8–9

For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.

Together, open the flashcard for Grace. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

2 Samuel 9:6–8, 13

Mephibosheth is not in the chapter. A lame man from a fallen house is seated at the king's table for someone else's sake. That is the drawing, in a story.

And Mephibosheth the son of Jonathan, son of Saul, came to David and fell on his face and paid homage. And David said, "Mephibosheth!" And he answered, "Behold, I am your servant." And David said to him, "Do not fear, for I will show you kindness for the sake of your father Jonathan, and I will restore to you all the land of Saul your father, and you shall eat at my table always." And he paid homage and said, "What is your servant, that you should show regard for a dead dog such as I?" ... So Mephibosheth lived in Jerusalem, for he ate always at the king's table.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What had Mephibosheth done to earn a seat? What, exactly, did David give him?

CORE

Leader. Nothing earned. Land restored, fear lifted, a permanent place at the table, and the reason is Jonathan, not Mephibosheth's résumé.

2. He calls himself "a dead dog." Does David argue with that self-portrait, or does he simply set a place for him?

Leader. Grace does not wait for a healthier self-image. It seats the person who knows he does not belong.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 2:8–9 says the gift includes the faith that receives it, "so that no one may boast." What do we still try to slide onto the table as our contribution? CORE

Leader. Sincerity, a decision, a sad enough repentance, church loyalty, not being as bad as someone else.

4. Romans 6:1 asks if we should sin so grace will abound. Where does “grace means my sin does not matter” misunderstand the feast?

Leader. The table is for transformation as well as welcome. Titus 2:11–12: grace trains us. It is not a permit.

5. 2 Corinthians 8:9: He became poor so we might become rich. Grace was free to us and costly to Him. How does remembering the cost keep gratitude from turning into entitlement?

Leader. Entitlement says “of course.” Worship says “it cost Him.” Ask what entitlement sounds like in prayer.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Grace is God giving sinners the opposite of what they deserve, at Jesus’ cost, as a gift.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Give something good to someone who cannot pay you back and does not share your faith. Say it is a gift, not a trade. If the door opens, tell

them grace is God giving sinners the opposite of what they deserve, at Jesus' cost.

Leader. Watch the urge to post it. The gift is for them. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God for a seat you did not earn.
2. Name one boast you keep wanting to add.
3. Ask that grace would train the group this week, not only comfort it.

Before you stumble

Part I ends here. Do not start Part II tonight unless you have time for a clean handoff. A good last line: "Next time we tell the truth about why this table was necessary." Some in the room may not feel like sinners yet. Do not force a testimony. The text can indict gently.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what a team banquet feels like if you did not make the team and the coach seats you anyway. Then ask who paid for the meal. Keep Jesus as the cost, not the coach as the hero.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Titus 2:11–14. Grace appeared, and grace trains. Use it if Romans 6 needs a second witness.